



**Networking and information Technology
Research and Development (NITRD)
National Coordination Office (NCO)
National Science Foundation (NSF)**

**REQUEST FOR INFORMATION ON THE
DEVELOPMENT OF AN ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE
(AI) ACTION PLAN**

Capabilities Statement

Solicitation Number:
March 15, 2025 | 11:59 PM (ET)

SUBMITTED TO:

Faisal D'Souza
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SUBMITTED BY:

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Status:

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SBA Certified Minority-Owned Small Business

SBA Certified 8(a) Firm

March 15, 2025

Networking and Information Technology Research and Development (NITRD)
National Coordination Office (NCO)
National Science Foundation (NSF)

ATTN: Faisal D'Souza,
Technical Coordinator, NCO

Subject: Request for Information on the Development of an Artificial Intelligence (AI) Action Plan – Capabilities Statement

Dear Mr. Faisal D'Souza,

WhitworthKee Consulting, LLC and its partner, 66degrees, appreciate the opportunity to respond to the request for information (RFI). WKC is a Washington, D.C.-based research firm specializing in strategic planning, action plan development, mixed-methods research, program evaluation, policy analysis, and program assessment for federal, state, private industry, higher education institutions, and non-profit organizations. WKC serves as a trusted partner to federal agencies, providing data-driven insights to inform strategic decision-making and policy development. As an 8(a)-certified small business, WKC offers expertise to ensure research initiatives and strategic plans align with organizational goals, national priorities, and deliver measurable, impactful outcomes. Through rigorous evaluation methodologies, stakeholder engagement, and evidence-based recommendations, WKC helps organizations optimize program effectiveness, strengthen research capacity, and advance national objectives in STEM education and workforce development.

66degrees, with over a decade of experience in data-driven solutions and AI-powered analytics, brings technical expertise in developing and implementing AI applications that are essential for extracting insights from large-scale datasets and supporting strategic decision-making. 66degrees' capabilities in AI-driven analytics, data visualization, and large language model (LLM)-powered solutions enable them to identify patterns, derive meaningful insights, and enhance policy recommendations. 66degrees has successfully implemented AI Action Plans in the private sector across multiple industries, ensuring responsible and effective deployment of AI-powered solutions. Their experience in AI governance, cybersecurity, and data management strengthens their ability to support public-sector agencies in designing and implementing AI-driven strategies that align with national priorities.

WKC and 66degrees formed a strategic partnership to provide recommendations for the AI Action Plan, leveraging the synergy between WKC's extensive experience in supporting critical research programs in science and technology and 66degrees' deep expertise in AI-driven solutions. WKC brings a proven track record of collaboration with the National Science Foundation (NSF), expertise in action plan development, and policy analysis, while 66degrees offers over a decade of experience in data-driven solutions and AI-powered analytics, specializing in AI application development and strategic decision-making support.

This synergy enables our partnership to deliver comprehensive, data-driven recommendations tailored to NITRD's objectives in developing an effective AI Action Plan. Together, WKC and 66degrees offer a balanced approach that merges policy expertise with technical AI innovation, ensuring that the AI Action Plan is both strategically structured and operationally feasible.



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If you have any questions, please contact me at [REDACTED] or [REDACTED]

Sincerely,

Chad E. Kee, Ph.D.
CEO and Founder, WhitworthKee Consulting

[REDACTED]

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1.0 UNDERSTANDING THE NEED

The Networking and Information Technology Research and Development (NITRD) program is a coalition of 23 federal agencies dedicated to researching and developing advanced information technology (IT) capabilities to empower federal missions, support U.S. leadership in science, engineering, and technology, and bolster U.S. economic competitiveness. As AI continues to transform industries, national security, and global markets, implementing a comprehensive AI Action Plan is critical to ensure that NITRD's investment in AI and IT research is strategically aligned, efficiently allocated, and effectively transitioned into real-world applications. As stated in the RFI, the AI Action Plan will define the priority policy actions necessary to sustain and enhance the nation's AI leadership, while ensuring that unnecessary regulatory burdens do not hinder private-sector AI innovation. A structured approach prevents federal AI research efforts from becoming fragmented, duplicative, or slow to transition into operational use, mitigating risks that could delay AI-driven advancements across government agencies and the private sector.

A well-defined AI Action Plan will enhance coordination among the 23 NITRD member agencies, aligning them under a unified AI research and policy strategy that fosters innovation, strengthens security, and drives economic growth. By ensuring that AI research funding is directed toward high-impact areas—such as AI-driven cybersecurity, quantum computing, and AI-optimized networking technologies—the plan will eliminate inefficiencies and reduce redundant projects.

Additionally, the AI Action Plan will accelerate the transition of AI research into operational capabilities, facilitating faster adoption of AI-driven solutions in national defense, healthcare, and public-sector applications. By establishing a cohesive roadmap, the NITRD program can strengthen collaboration between government, industry, and academia, ensuring that AI research and development efforts propel scientific, technological, and economic progress.

Cybersecurity remains a top priority, as AI-powered cyber threats—including AI-enhanced malware, deepfake attacks, and adversarial AI exploitation—pose an immediate risk to national security and IT infrastructure. Current cybersecurity strategies are not fully adapted to mitigate AI-specific threats, leaving government networks and sensitive data vulnerable. The AI Action Plan will address these concerns by advancing AI-driven cybersecurity tools, developing AI-specific security protocols, and funding adversarial AI research to prevent AI-driven cyberattacks, disinformation campaigns, and model manipulation threats. Strengthening AI-enabled threat intelligence sharing across agencies will ensure a coordinated, proactive response to emerging AI threats, protecting federal IT systems, national defense networks, and critical infrastructure.

Beyond security and infrastructure, the AI Action Plan will drive public-private partnerships to accelerate AI commercialization and workforce development. Many AI innovations require collaboration between government, academia, and industry to achieve widespread deployment. By facilitating technology transfer programs, AI breakthroughs developed in federal research labs can transition into industry applications, ensuring that AI research translates into real-world impact. Additionally, expanding AI workforce training programs will help address the national shortage of AI professionals, ensuring that both the public and private sectors have the talent needed to sustain long-term AI innovation.

2.0 INTRODUCING WKC & 66DEGREES: EXPERTS IN AI POLICY, ACTION PLAN DEVELOPMENT, AND DATA-DRIVEN DECISION-MAKING

WhitworthKee Consulting (WKC) and 66 degrees (referenced as the WKC-66degrees team) brings together deep expertise in AI policy, strategic planning, research evaluation, and data-driven decision-making—making us uniquely qualified to provide recommendations on the highest priority policy actions for the AI Action Plan. Our combined capabilities align with the NITRD program's mission and directly supports the goals and priorities of

the National Science Foundation (NSF), which is one of the 23-member agencies of the NITRD program, in advancing AI research, governance, and workforce development.



WKC is a Washington, D.C.-based research consulting firm specializing in strategic planning, developing action plans, mixed-methods research, program evaluation, policy analysis, and program assessment for federal, state, private industry, higher education institutions, and non-profit organizations. With deep expertise in research and evaluation, WKC serves as a trusted partner to federal agencies providing data-driven insights to inform strategic decision-making and policy development.

As an 8(a)-certified small business, WKC offers expertise in data-driven strategy development, program assessment, and technical assistance, ensuring that federal research initiatives and strategic plans align with organizational goals, national priorities, and drive measurable, impactful outcomes. Through rigorous evaluation methodologies, stakeholder engagement, and evidence-based recommendations, WKC helps organizations and research and development programs optimize effectiveness, strengthen research capacity, and advance national objectives in STEM, AI, and workforce development.

With a proven track record of supporting research, workforce development, STEM education, and federal initiatives, WKC has successfully guided organizations through data-driven strategic planning, action plan implementation, and comprehensive evaluations that drive measurable outcomes in areas such as STEM, education, and workforce development. Our expertise ensures that policy decisions, funding strategies, and program initiatives are aligned with national priorities, organizational goals, research and development initiatives, and emerging trends in science, technology, and workforce innovation.

WKC's experience includes supporting agencies, research and development programs, and organizations such as the National Science Foundation (NSF), Department of Labor (DOL), the Delaware Department of Education, and colleges and universities advance research capacity, STEM workforce expansion, and program assessment through several high-impact approaches.

WKC can leverage these experiences with NSF and our wide range of other clients in performing action planning to assist the NITRD program in executing the mandate and intent of Executive Order (EO) 14179, *Removing Barriers to American Leadership in Artificial Intelligence*. With deep expertise in both quantitative and qualitative methods, our staff has successfully supported clients in developing strategic plans grounded in data that are actionable, achievable, right sized, and that fit into the organization's existing environment, operations, and infrastructure. We help create strategic plans that guide the client by creating actionable goals that are inherently flexible to allow the client to adapt to changing environments and priorities, serving as the compass to keep all eyes focused on the end goal.

66degrees WKC is proud to partner with 66degrees, a leading AI and data consulting firm helping organizations build AI-powered solutions and harness AI-driven insights. 66degrees, with over a decade of experience in AI development and implementation, brings technical expertise in AI applications that are essential for extracting insights from large-scale datasets and informing AI policy recommendations. Their capabilities in AI-driven analytics, data visualization, and large language model (LLM)-powered solutions enable them to identify patterns, derive meaningful insights, and support data-driven decision-making. 66degrees, with over a decade of experience in AI development, deployment, and governance, has successfully implemented AI Action Plans in the private sector across multiple industries. Their expertise spans topics identified in the RFI, including explainability and assurance of AI model outputs, cybersecurity, data privacy and security, risk management, regulation and governance, research and development, education and workforce, and AI-driven innovation and competition. By integrating AI solutions into real-world

applications, 66degrees has helped organizations develop responsible, scalable, and transparent AI Action Plans that align with business objectives, regulatory frameworks, and national priorities.

By combining WKC's action plan development and policy expertise with 66degrees' technical capabilities in AI development and data analytics, the WKC-66degrees team can deliver high-impact recommendations that ensure the AI Action Plan is both forward thinking, implementable, and sustainable.

3.0 IMPLEMENTATION ROADMAP: A STRATEGIC FOUNDATION FOR AI POLICY ACTIONS

Before executing AI policy actions, we strongly recommend the NITRD program begin with a structured implementation roadmap. This roadmap will serve as a strategic framework to ensure that AI policies are coordinated, actionable, and adaptable to the evolving AI landscape. A well-defined roadmap will provide clear priorities, funding strategies, and governance structures, enabling responsible AI adoption while maintaining U.S. leadership in AI innovation. More specifically, we recommend that the Implementation Roadmap include the following 10 components. Details about each component is presented below.

1. Establishing a National AI Ethics and Governance Structure
2. Prioritizing Funding for AI Research & Privacy-Preserving AI
3. Developing National AI Privacy and Security Guidelines
4. Investing in AI Education and Workforce Development
5. Establishing a National AI Innovation Fund & Promote Open-Source AI
6. Developing Standardized AI Testing and Explainability Benchmarks
7. Incentivizing Responsible AI Adoption in the Private Sector
8. Creating an AI Risk Assessment and Governance Framework
9. Funding AI Pilot Programs in High-Impact Sectors
10. Strengthening AI Cybersecurity for National Security

A critical first step in this roadmap is the **establishment of national AI ethics and governance structure (1)**. This includes creating a National AI Ethics Board, composed of experts from diverse fields, to oversee AI development, establish ethical guidelines, and advise on modifications to existing policies and identifying the need for new policies. Additionally, a Multi-Stakeholder AI Forum should be launched to ensure continuous collaboration between industry, academia, civil society, and government, allowing AI policies to remain adaptive to emerging challenges and advancements.

To maintain U.S. leadership in AI research and development (R&D), the federal government **must prioritize funding for AI research and privacy-preserving AI (2)** through agencies such as NSF, the Defense Advanced Research Project Agency (DARPA), and the National Institutes of Health (NIH). Investments should focus on explainable AI (XAI), privacy-preserving AI techniques (e.g., federated learning, differential privacy, homomorphic encryption), and AI safety mechanisms that defend against adversarial attacks and bias. Increased funding in these areas will enhance AI transparency, security, and public trust while enabling ethical AI integration across sectors.

Additionally, **national AI privacy and security guidelines (3)** must be developed to protect sensitive data and mitigate AI-related cybersecurity threats. The National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) could take the lead in establishing adaptable security protocols, ensuring AI systems meet best practices for data collection, storage, usage, sharing, disposal, and security. These privacy and security guidelines must also address AI-specific cyber risks, such as model inversion, data poisoning attacks, and adversarial manipulations, creating a standardized security baseline for industry and government adoption.

As AI continues to reshape the job market, the U.S. must **invest in AI education and workforce development (4)**. AI literacy should be integrated into K-12 education, as well as an expansion of AI-focused degree programs in universities and community colleges. A national AI workforce retraining initiative should provide scholarships, apprenticeships, and industry partnerships to prepare workers for AI-driven automation. These efforts will ensure that the U.S. maintains a strong, competitive, and diverse AI workforce that is prepared to drive innovation.

To encourage AI-driven innovation, the federal government should **establish a National AI Innovation Fund (5)** and promote open-source AI development. This fund would support AI applications with clear societal benefits, while also fostering public-private AI research collaborations. Open-source AI should be encouraged through grants, competitions, and the development of a national AI model repository, increasing transparency, and responsible AI adoption across industries.

Ensuring **standardized AI testing and explainability benchmarks (6)** is another essential component of the roadmap. NIST, in collaboration with the National AI Ethics Board, should establish AI evaluation standards to ensure models are transparent, interpretable, and aligned with fairness and reliability metrics. Standardized AI testing will provide the necessary safeguards for AI deployment in critical industries such as healthcare, finance, and national security, fostering trust in AI systems and promoting responsible implementation.

To further drive ethical AI adoption, **incentivizing responsible AI development in the private sector (7)** is crucial. The federal government should offer tax credits, grants, or regulatory relief to organizations that demonstrate adherence to ethical AI guidelines, use explainable AI techniques, and prioritize data privacy and security. These incentives will help align AI industry growth with national policy objectives, ensuring that AI advances responsibly while mitigating potential risks.

A **structured AI risk assessment and governance framework (8)** must also be developed to manage potential AI-related risks. A national AI risk classification framework should be created to evaluate bias, security vulnerabilities, and prevent economic disruptions stemming from AI technologies. Adaptive AI regulations should be introduced to balance innovation and governance, ensuring AI applications remain safe, transparent, and beneficial to society.

To ensure AI policies translate into effective real-world applications, **funding AI pilot programs across high-impact sectors (9)** is essential. Examples of high-impact sectors include healthcare, finance, transportation, and criminal justice where pilot programs will help gather real-world data on AI deployment challenges, best practices, and long-term impacts. These pilot programs will serve as a bridge between AI research and practical deployment, ensuring AI adoption is informed, responsible, and scalable.

Lastly, **AI-driven cybersecurity (10)** must be prioritized as critical to national security. Federal agencies such as the Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency (DARPA), the Intelligence Advanced Research Projects Activity (IARPA), and the National Security Administration (NSA) should invest in AI-powered cybersecurity tools that detect and counter AI-driven cyber threats while strengthening AI-enhanced intelligence-sharing mechanisms across government agencies. As AI-powered cyber threats continue to evolve, proactive investment in AI-driven defense systems is critical to protecting U.S. infrastructure and digital assets.

Implementing this AI Action Plan roadmap will provide clear policy direction and funding priorities, ensuring that AI initiatives align with national objectives related to security, workforce development, and technological innovation. By fostering collaboration across government agencies, industry leaders, and academic institutions, this structured approach will accelerate the responsible deployment of AI technologies while maintaining ethical standards and risk mitigation strategies. Through a phased and strategic implementation process, the

NITRD program and its federal partners can reinforce U.S. leadership in AI innovation, strengthen AI governance frameworks, and support sustainable, equitable, and forward-thinking AI development.

4.0 RECOMMENDATIONS ON HIGHEST PRIORITY POLICY ACTIONS TO INCLUDE IN THE AI ACTION PLAN

The WKC-66degrees team has identified the highest priority policy actions for inclusion in the AI Action Plan based on our expertise in AI research, action planning, policy analysis, cybersecurity, data governance, and workforce development. These recommendations were chosen based on their critical role in ensuring AI's safe, responsible, and effective deployment across sectors, aligning with national security, economic growth, workforce expansion, and ethical AI governance. The priority actions outlined below reflect the most pressing AI policy challenges and the concrete steps needed to address them.

1. Cybersecurity: Strengthening AI-Powered Defense Mechanisms

AI-driven cyber threats are rapidly evolving, posing significant risks to national security, critical infrastructure, and public trust. To fortify cybersecurity defenses, we recommend:

- Investing in research on AI-driven cybersecurity threats and defenses to enhance threat detection, risk mitigation, and AI-based security protocols.
- Developing AI-powered cybersecurity tools to protect critical infrastructure, detect adversarial AI threats, and enable real-time threat intelligence sharing between federal agencies and private-sector partners.

As cyberattacks become more AI-driven, there is an urgent need for AI-enhanced cybersecurity solutions to counter AI-generated misinformation, deepfake technology, and autonomous hacking systems. Proactively investing in AI-driven defense systems will ensure U.S. leadership in AI security and infrastructure protection.

2. Risks, Regulation, & Governance: Establishing a Robust AI Policy Framework

To ensure AI development aligns with ethical and security considerations, a strong risk management and governance framework is essential. For this, we recommend:

- Creating a framework for assessing and managing AI risks, ensuring AI deployment prioritizes safety, transparency, and fairness while mitigating potential harm.
- Convening a multi-stakeholder forum of industry leaders, academia, government, and civil society representatives to develop ethical AI guidelines and best practices that focus on transparency, interpretability, fairness, and accountability.

Without clear AI risk governance structures, bias, misinformation, and security vulnerabilities can undermine AI's societal benefits. A structured policy framework will support AI innovation while ensuring ethical oversight and public accountability.

3. Explainability and Assurance of AI Model Outputs: Enhancing AI Trust and Transparency

AI models must be explainable, transparent, and interpretable to ensure accountability and mitigate unintended consequences. To do so, we recommend:

- Developing and promoting standardized testing and evaluation methods for AI explainability, ensuring AI models produce transparent, auditable, and fair outputs.
- Establishing a public repository of open-source models and tools to encourage wider adoption and shared best practices, accelerating the development of trustworthy AI systems.

AI decision-making must be understandable to users, regulators, and the public to ensure trust and ethical deployment. Standardizing AI testing and open-source collaboration will reduce biases, improve model reliability, and foster responsible AI innovation.

4. Application and Use (Private Sector & Government): Ensuring Responsible AI Deployment

AI must be effectively integrated into diverse industries while maintaining ethical considerations and security. We recommend:

- Funding pilot programs that demonstrate AI's real-world applications across high-impact sectors such as healthcare, finance, national security, and public administration.
- Developing best practices and guidelines for responsible AI deployment in government agencies, ensuring compliance with ethical AI principles and data security.
- Incentivizing private sector AI adoption through tax credits and grants for companies demonstrating responsible AI implementation and measurable societal benefits.
- Establishing a National AI Ethics Board to oversee AI development and ensure adherence to ethical standards and governance principles.

AI's full potential cannot be realized without clear guidance on responsible deployment. These policies will enable AI adoption in the public and private sectors while ensuring security, fairness, and alignment with national priorities.

5. Data Privacy & Security: Safeguarding AI Systems Against Threats

AI systems depend on vast amounts of data, making privacy and security paramount. To ensure that data are safeguarded, we recommend:

- Developing comprehensive AI data privacy and security guidelines to prevent unauthorized access, data misuse, and AI model exploitation.
- Supporting privacy-preserving AI techniques such as federated learning and differential privacy to enhance secure data handling and compliance with emerging AI regulations.

Without strong privacy safeguards, AI adoption risks undermining public trust. Ensuring data security and privacy-respecting AI models will be critical for national security, consumer protection, and regulatory compliance.

6. Education & Workforce Development: Preparing for an AI-Driven Future

A highly skilled workforce is necessary to drive AI innovation and maintain U.S. leadership. We recommend:

- Expanding AI education and workforce training programs including within the K-12 space through higher education as well as offering continuing education.
- Supporting workforce reskilling initiatives to prepare professionals for AI-integrated industries and bridge the AI talent gap.

As AI adoption grows, workforce readiness is a national priority. Expanding AI education and training opportunities will ensure a competitive, diverse, and highly skilled AI workforce.

7. Innovation & Competition: Fostering AI Growth While Ensuring Fair Access

To sustain U.S. leadership in AI innovation, funding and regulatory policies must support healthy competition. We recommend:

- Establishing a National AI Innovation Fund to support the development of innovative AI applications and prevent monopolization in AI research and development.
- Promoting open-source AI development and collaboration, ensuring a more competitive and transparent AI ecosystem.
- Implementing policies that prevent monopolies while ensuring fair access to AI data, resources, and funding.

AI-driven economic growth should not be concentrated in a few dominant firms. Supporting open innovation and funding opportunities will ensure broad participation in AI advancements.

8. Research & Development: Strengthening U.S. AI Leadership

To ensure long-term AI leadership, fundamental AI research must be prioritized. We recommend:

- Increasing funding for AI R&D to support breakthrough innovations and maintain U.S. competitiveness.
- Fostering collaboration between academia, industry, and government to accelerate AI research translation into real-world applications.

Continued investment in AI research will drive long-term technological advancements, ensuring the U.S. remains at the forefront of global AI development.

The WKC-66degrees team has identified these priority AI policy actions based on their critical role in ensuring AI's responsible deployment, security, and economic impact. Our recommendations provide a balanced approach that supports AI innovation, mitigates risks, enhances workforce development, and ensures AI governance remains adaptable to emergent and evolving needs. By implementing these strategic, high-priority AI policies, the NITRD program and its federal partners will position the U.S. to lead in AI research, governance, and workforce preparedness, while ensuring AI is ethical, transparent, and aligned with national interests.

5.0 RELEVANT STAFF EXPERIENCE

Chad Kee, Ph.D., CEO and Founder, WKC. Dr. Kee is an entrepreneur, researcher, and educator with extensive experience in research, program evaluation, and strategic planning. He founded WKC in 2016 to provide data-driven insights and evidence-based solutions that help organizations assess program effectiveness, improve decision-making, and achieve measurable outcomes. His expertise lies in designing and implementing evaluations, policy analysis, and technical assessments to support federal agencies, universities, and workforce development initiatives.

Dr. Kee holds a Master's degree in Sociology with a focus on urban education from the University of North Carolina Charlotte and a Doctorate in Educational Leadership and Policy Studies from Iowa State University, specializing in higher education, student affairs, and policy analysis. His academic and professional background has positioned him as a trusted expert in research design, data analysis, and program evaluation.

As CEO of WKC, Dr. Kee works directly with the firm's federal, state, and institutional partners, including NSF, DOL, the Delaware Department of Education, universities and colleges, and the United Negro College Fund (UNCF). He leads efforts to develop evaluation frameworks, conduct research assessments, and provide strategic

planning support to organizations implementing education, workforce, and research initiatives. His role involves overseeing technical evaluations, directing large-scale research projects, and guiding organizations in using data to inform policy and program decisions.

Under Dr. Kee's leadership, WKC has become a recognized partner in program assessment and evaluation, delivering actionable insights and strategic recommendations to support federal agencies, educational institutions, and workforce programs in their mission to enhance research capacity, program impact, and long-term sustainability.

Kevin Hylton, Ph.D., Vice President of Research and Evaluation, WKC. Dr. Kevin Hylton is a seasoned research and evaluation expert with nearly 30 years of experience in research, higher education, and program evaluation. His expertise spans behavioral science and policy analysis with a strong focus on STEM education, workforce development, and program evaluation. Throughout his career, he has led evaluations and assessments for major federal agencies, including the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC), the National Science Foundation (NSF), and the Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration (SAMHSA). His experience also includes extensive work with colleges and universities, including working with institutions that are historically underresourced such as teaching colleges and Historically Black Colleges and Universities (HBCUs), to advance research capacity. Currently, Dr. Hylton serves as Project Director for the National Science Foundation (NSF) Robert Noyce Teacher Scholarship Program, where he leads efforts to strengthen STEM education pathways, expand research capacity, and promote workforce development. He previously served as the Project Director for the evaluation of a pilot program which focused on expanding the reach of EPSCoR to institutions that have historically not applied. His expertise in program evaluation, data analysis, and workforce development makes him a key contributor to WKC's strategic research initiatives and national education policy recommendations.

As Vice President of Research and Evaluation at WKC, Dr. Hylton is responsible for establishing and directing the company's research and evaluation priorities. He leads WKC's efforts in strategic planning, mixed-methods research, and policy analysis, ensuring that federal research initiatives and strategic plans align with national priorities in STEM education, workforce development, and program effectiveness. His role includes directing and managing high-profile education and workforce-related contracts within educational institutions, nonprofit organizations, private industry, and the public sector.

Dr. Hylton oversees the development of literature reviews, evaluation designs, environmental scans, and the creation of quantitative and qualitative data collection instruments to support data-driven decision-making in STEM education and workforce expansion. He is also responsible for analyzing data, producing technical reports, and delivering actionable insights to federal agencies and research institutions. Dr. Hylton holds a PhD in Sociology from Howard University.

Tiffani Miller, Ph.D., Vice President of Research and Evaluation, WKC. Dr. Miller is responsible for guiding research priorities and evaluation strategies at WKC. She is an expert in strategic planning, program evaluation, and policy analysis, with over 15 years of experience across the government, nonprofit, and private sectors. Dr. Miller has led and contributed to numerous large-scale strategic planning and evaluation initiatives designed to strengthen community, health, and economic development efforts. She played a pivotal role in developing a strategic framework for the Pioneer Valley Planning Commission (PVPC) Economic Fund, contributed to the long-term strategic planning for the Michigan City Economic Development Corporation's Strategic Plan through 2040, and led a community needs assessment for a Chase Bank-funded initiative, evaluating the economic and health impacts of food-related programs in a Baton Rouge community. She employs a collaborative, participatory

approach that actively engages key partners and communities, ensuring that strategic planning and evaluation efforts reflect an array of perspectives and produce reliable, client-centered insights.

Dr. Miller has also served on national advisory committees for agencies, including USDA, FDA, DoD, and CDC, where she has contributed to the development of public health policies and frameworks. She holds a PhD in Comparative Medicine from Michigan State University, an M.S. in Environmental Health Science from the University of Georgia, and a B.S. in Chemistry.

Molly Matthews-Ewald, Ph.D., Director of Research and Evaluation, WKC. Dr. Matthews-Ewald, Director of Research and Evaluation, has more than 17 years of experience in mixed methods research and evaluation. She has extensive experience in strategic planning, including organizational alignment, stakeholder engagement, and data-driven decision-making. As Director of Research and Evaluation, she specializes in guiding mission-driven organizations through structured planning processes that drive measurable impact. She has supported an array of federal agencies including, but not limited to, the (1) NSF; (2) Administration for Children & Families/Office of Planning, Research & Evaluation; (3) Health Resources & Services Administration/Maternal and Child Health Bureau; (4) Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services; (5) CDC; (6) U.S. Department of Agriculture/Food and Nutrition Service (USDA FNS); (7) SAMHSA; and, (8) USDA/Economic Research Service. She currently serves as Deputy Project Director for all NSF projects at WKC, including the Evaluation of the Robert Noyce Teacher Scholarship Program. While at West Virginia University, Dr. Matthews-Ewald collaborated with the West Virginia State Health Department on several initiatives to evaluate its work, including the multi-million-dollar CDC-funded Communities Putting Prevention to Work (CPPW), which included coordinating with a variety of partners and assessing the impact of local policies. Dr. Matthews-Ewald has a wealth of experience supporting and working with groups focused on a single topic – through technical working groups, advisory committees, and Communities of Practice. Dr. Matthews-Ewald has experience working with organizational leadership to engage in interactive sensemaking sessions to identify particularly salient and actionable areas—supporting the organizations’ health. A hallmark of the approach is active engagement and collaboration, taking this approach for both federal (e.g., NSF, CDC, SAMHSA, FNS) and non-federal (e.g., Blue Cross Blue Shield Foundation of North Carolina, American Heart Association, West Virginia Department of Health and Human Services) clients. Dr. Matthews-Ewald holds a PhD Public Health Sciences from West Virginia University.

Justin Harris, Ph.D., Principal Solution Architect, 66degrees. Dr. Harris is a seasoned AI/ML expert with over a decade of experience in delivering impactful solutions across diverse industries. As a Principal Solution Architect, he deeply understands business needs and translates them into practical, data-driven solutions. His expertise spans a wide range of AI/ML techniques, including natural language processing, computer vision, and machine learning, which he leverages to solve complex problems and drive measurable business outcomes. Dr. Harris has a proven track record of successfully architecting, designing, and implementing AI/ML projects in both the private and public sector. His passion for technology and commitment to outcome-driven design have made him a sought-after speaker and thought leader in the AI/ML. He is a strong advocate for the power of AI/ML to transform businesses and has actively contributed to the growth of the AI/ML ecosystem through his work with Google and other industry organizations. Dr. Harris holds a PhD in Chemical Engineering from The University of Texas at Austin.

Kolin Konjura, MA., Data Science Solutions Architect, 66degrees. Kolin Konjura is a data science solutions architect with extensive experience in machine learning, cloud computing, and data-driven decision-making. He specializes in end-to-end data solutions, AI and machine learning model development, and Machine Learning Operations (MLOps) to improve optimize enterprise operations and enhance AI-driven analytics. With a strong background in mathematical modeling, data engineering, and cloud-based AI architectures, Mr. Konjura has

successfully led large-scale AI implementations across multiple industries, including finance, logistics, healthcare, and consumer goods.

Currently, Mr. Konjura serves as a Data Science Solutions Architect at 66degrees, where he leads AI and machine learning initiatives that support organizations in leveraging advanced data analytics, cloud solutions, and AI-powered technologies. Previously, he held leadership roles in AI and MLOps at Capgemini, XPO Logistics, and Baker Tilly US, where he managed AI-driven business solutions, cloud-based machine learning pipelines, and enterprise AI governance strategies. His experience includes developing AI-powered cybersecurity solutions, enhancing AI explainability frameworks, and implementing large-scale ML model deployments across distributed cloud environments.

Mr. Konjura has a strong academic background in mathematics and data science, holding a Master's degree in Mathematics from the University of Tennessee, Knoxville, and a Bachelor of Science in Mathematics from the University of Wisconsin-Milwaukee.

6.0 CONCLUSION: A UNIFIED TEAM FOR AI POLICY DEVELOPMENT

Together, the WKC-66degrees Team brings a comprehensive, multi-disciplinary approach to AI policy and strategic planning, ensuring that the AI Action Plan:

- Defines critical AI policy priorities that support U.S. leadership in AI research, cybersecurity, and workforce development.
- Strengthens AI research coordination and investment strategies to maximize the impact of the NITRD program's \$11.1 billion in annual R&D funding.
- Supports responsible AI deployment by establishing clear AI governance, regulatory, and risk management frameworks.
- Drives AI workforce expansion and STEM education to build a robust AI talent pipeline for the public and private sectors.
- Fosters public-private partnerships to ensure AI innovations transition seamlessly from research to real-world applications.

We welcome the opportunity to collaborate with the NITRD program and its federal partners in developing the Implementation Roadmap and AI Action Plan, shaping a forward-thinking strategy that promotes ethical AI deployment, strengthens national security, and advances workforce development. Our collective efforts will ensure that the U.S. remains at the forefront of AI innovation, fostering a responsible, secure, and competitive AI ecosystem that aligns with national priorities and global leadership in emerging technologies.